five hundred years, beginning in the seventh century. In some areas the Jain religion continued to be practised but by the twelfth century Buddhism had been all but extinguished throughout the subcontinent. So complete was the triumph of Vaishnavism and Shaivism that to say today that Jainism and Buddhism were both once widespread throughout much of South India is to be greeted with polite disbelief. The historians who accompanied the Arab, Turkic and Mongol invasions reported the existence of only one ‘infidel’ religion in India, and the Portuguese and the Dutch followed suit. It was not until Sir William Jones and his fellow Orientalists began their enquiries in the 1780s that this veil over the past began to be lifted.



The former Jain temple of Chitharal with a Hindu gopuram above, as photographed in about 1900 by the Travancore State artist and photographer C. Neelakanta Pillai.